

Episode 133: Once Upon a Time... 77 – 1994 Part 11 – *Sailor Moon S* Movie: More Colour Carbon Blues

I wrote "Aren't there fewer cicadas this year?" last time. The manuscript stating "I don't know about other areas, but Nakano definitely has fewer cicadas this year" was published worldwide, and starting the next day: this year's cicadas are in full frenzy again.

Cicadas start singing before 4 AM when the eastern sky begins whitening, continue shrilly singing, take a break during the day's hottest (heated) 1-3 PM, then sing continuously from evening until midnight.

Simply wonderful (wry laugh).

At this pace, surely lots of cicadas will sing seven years from now too.

Currently in top form are minmin cicadas. Gradually aburazemi voices increase, eventually shifting to tsukutsukuboshi. When that happens, "autumn" approaches.

Now then.

Sailor Moon S movie, having decided on blue carbon for enemy characters and white carbon introduction—after deciding, I was actually called by a production executive.

"Is coloured carbon absolutely necessary for this?"

Actually, coloured carbon is somewhat expensive. At the time, regular black carbon cost about 17-18 yen per sheet, while coloured carbon cost over 20 yen. Plus prices varied somewhat by colour.

Furthermore, a problem. Actually, coloured carbon had absolutely limited distribution quantities. For brown carbon, which is sometimes used project-wide, there's reasonable distribution, but white and blue are used only in extremely special cases, so while Toei had some in-house stock, outsourced production houses—much less Philippine and Korean studios handling in-between and finishing work—essentially had zero inventory. So when ordering, we'd need to provide necessary quantities to production houses along with cuts.

The biggest problem wasn't money but usage volume. Though it's presumptuous for me to say, money could work out somehow. It's a theatrical work. But if we faced a "not enough carbon!" situation at crucial points during production, that would be serious.

From what I heard, increasing coloured carbon production is quite difficult, and requesting increased production today wouldn't be ready tomorrow or the day after. Plus operationally, machines must make large batches at once—you can't make just what you need when you need it. "Instead using all colour trace..." was no longer possible.

"Yes. Nothing but white carbon and blue carbon will work!" I said.

We roughly counted from storyboards how many cuts "Snow Kaguya" and "Snow Dancers" would appear in to estimate usage, but anyway, it's a theatrical version. They'd probably move energetically throughout, so we decided to prepare lots! I think manufacturer Josai Duplo had reasonable inventory too.

Thus we plunged into main feature work, but first various problems emerged from advance trailer cut work.

First, one animation problem. Cuts where regular black carbon characters and coloured carbon characters appear simultaneously must have animation on separate cels. Actually coloured carbon and black carbon have different heat requirements during transfer, so simultaneous carbon transfer to one cel is impossible.

Well, strictly speaking, they can be "composited" on one cel, but that requires some knowledge and care, and considering mass production systems centered on overseas work with tight schedules and somewhat uncertain communication, separating in-between animation in advance was safer. So in-between animation that originally would finish in one cel increased to two or three cels per character.

And yet another problem! Seeing painted Snow Kaguya cels, I was dumbfounded. Snow Kaguya using white carbon became—putting it nicely—colour trace painting, putting it badly—blurry painting that looked like front-back confusion, momentarily incomprehensible.

Here's what this means: animation cel paint painting applies paint from the back side, but naturally paint goes over main lines—carbon lines. With regular "black carbon" this isn't a problem at all, but with "white carbon," carbon lines themselves are semi-transparently thin, so they're overwhelmed by painted colours and look like there are no lines.

This was careless of me.

Actually when making colour samples for checking, I'd shown colour sample cels painted with black carbon with white carbon line-only cels overlaid to get "OK!" So they didn't get overwhelmed by cel paints like this—white lines properly emerged over painted colours for good feeling. Incidentally, blue carbon Snow Dancers were fine since painting colours themselves were white, so they didn't get overwhelmed much and rather finished nicely. The problem was definitely the queen.

Now what? (sweat) Main feature work had already started. Changes weren't possible now.

(10.08.10)

